

Can we see hints of dictation in the language of Cicero's letters?

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Writing from the Margins, Durham University, 15 May 2026

1. *Satis apparet ex eo quod hanc scribentium negligentiam damno, quid de illis **dictandi deliciis** sentiam. Nam in stilo quidem quamlibet properato dat aliquam cogitationi moram non consequens celeritatem eius manus: ille cui **dictamus** urget, atque interim pudet etiam dubitare aut resistere aut mutare quasi conscium infirmitatis nostrae timentis. Quo fit ut non rudia tantum et fortuita, sed inpropria interim, dum sola est conectendi sermonis cupiditas, effluant, quae nec scribentium curam nec dicentium impetum consequantur. At idem ille qui excipit, si tardior in scribendo aut incertior in legendo velut offensator fuerit, inhibetur cursus, atque omnis quae erat concepta mentis intentio mora et interdum iracundia excutitur. ... Denique, ut semel quod est potentissimum dicam, **secretum, quod dictando perit**, atque liberum arbitris locum et quam altissimum silentium scribentibus maxime convenire nemo dubitaverit.*

It is plain enough, from the fact that I condemn this carelessness in writers, what I think of those **indulgences of dictation**. For when one writes with the stylus, however hurriedly, the hand's failure to keep pace with the speed of thought still gives the mind some pause for reflection: but the man we are **dictating to** hurries us along, and meanwhile we are even ashamed to hesitate, to stop, to make changes — as if afraid that he should witness our weakness. The result is that not only crude and chance expressions, but sometimes improper ones, slip out — when the only desire is to keep the discourse flowing — that fall short both of a writer's care and of a speaker's force. And the very same scribe who is taking it down, if he is slower in writing or less certain in reading-back and stumbles, brings our pace to a halt, and all the mental concentration we had built up is shaken loose by the delay, and sometimes by anger. ... To name, in short, the strongest point: **privacy, which is destroyed by dictation** — undisturbed space and the deepest possible silence — is what suits a writer best, as no one will doubt. (Quintilian, *Institutio Oratoria* 10.3.19–22)

2. *Cum scripsissem haec infima quae sunt **mea manu**, venit ad nos Cicero tuus ad cenam, cum Pomponia foris cenaret. dedit mihi epistulam legendam tuam, quam paulo ante acceperat, Aristophaneo modo valde me hercule et suavem et gravem; qua sum admodum delectatus. dedit etiam alteram illam mihi, qua iubes eum mihi esse adfixum tamquam magistro. quam illum epistulae illae delectarunt, quam me! nihil puero illo suavius, nihil nostri amantius. **hoc inter cenam Tironi dictavi, ne mirere alia manu esse.***

When I had written the foregoing in **my own hand**, your young Cicero came to me for dinner, since Pomponia was dining out. He gave me a letter of yours to read, which he had received a little earlier — in the Aristophanic manner, really, both delightful and weighty; I was thoroughly delighted by it. He also gave me that other letter, in which you instruct him to attach himself to me as if to a teacher. How those letters delighted him, and me! Nothing is sweeter than that boy, nothing more affectionate to us. **I dictated this part to Tiro between courses, so don't be surprised that it is in another hand.** (Cicero, *ad Quintum fratrem* 3.1.19)

3. [on his recent letter to Varro:] *valdene tibi placuit? male mi sit si umquam quicquam tam enitar. ergo ne **Tironi** quidem **dictavi** qui totas περιόχας persequi solet sed **Spintharo syllabatim**.*

Did you really like it? May it go ill for me if I ever labour so hard over anything again. I did not even dictate it to **Tiro**, who is accustomed to take down whole sentences at a stretch, but to **Spintharus, syllable by syllable**. (Cicero, *ad Atticum* 13.25)

4. CICERO ATTICO salutem. *occupationum mearum vel hoc signum erit quod epistula librari manu est. de epistularum frequentia te nihil accuso, sed pleraeque tantum modo mihi nuntiabant ubi esses, vel etiam significabant recte esse, quod erant abs te.*

Cicero to Atticus, greetings. **Even this will be a sign of how busy I am: that this letter is in a scribe's hand.** As for the frequency of your letters, I make no complaint — but most of them only told me where you were, or simply indicated that things were well, by virtue of being from you at all. (Cicero, *ad Atticum* 4.16.1)

5. *tu mea curabis, ut curas. haec scripsi seu dictavi apposita secunda mensa apud Vestorium.*

You will look after my interests, as you do. **I wrote — or rather dictated — this over dessert at Vestorius's.** (Cicero, *ad Atticum* 14.21.4)

6. CICERO ATTICO salutem. *cum essem in Tusculano (erit hoc tibi pro illo tuo: cum essem in Ceramico) verum tamen cum ibi essem, Roma puer a sorore tua missus epistulam mihi abs te adlatam dedit nuntiavitque eo ipso die post meridiem iturum eum qui ad te proficisceretur. eo factum est ut epistulae tuae rescriberem aliquid, brevitatem temporis tam pauca cogere scribere.*

Cicero to Atticus, greetings. When I was at Tusculum (let this serve as a counterpart to your usual *cum essem in Ceramico*) — well, while I was there, **a slave-boy from Rome, sent by your sister, brought me a letter that had reached him from you and announced that on that very day, in the afternoon, the man going to you would be setting off.** So it has come about that I am writing some kind of reply to your letter — **but the shortness of time forces me to write so little.** (Cicero, *ad Atticum* 1.10.1)

7. *signa nostra et Hermeraclos, ut scribis, cum commodissime poteris velim imponas, et si quod aliud οἰκεῖον eius loci quem non ignoras reperies et maxime quae tibi palaestrae gymnasique videbuntur esse. etenim ibi sedens haec ad te scribebam ut me locus ipse admoneret. praeterea typos tibi mando quos in tectorio atrii possim includere et putealia sigillata duo. bibliothecam tuam cave cuiquam despondeas, quamvis acrem amatorem inveneris.*

Our statues and the herm-Heracles, as you write, I'd like you to ship whenever you most conveniently can; and if you find anything else suitable to that place — you know which I mean — particularly anything that strikes you as right **for a palaestra and gymnasium. For it was sitting there that I was writing this to you, the place itself prompting me.** Besides those, I commission from you reliefs that I can set into the stuccowork of my little atrium, and two sculpted well-heads. Don't, whatever you do, promise your library to anyone, however passionate a buyer you find. (Cicero, *ad Atticum* 1.10.3)

8. *de fratre confido ita esse ut semper volui et elaboravi. multa signa sunt eius rei, non minimum quod soror praegnas est. ... Tulliola tibi diem dat, sponsorem non appellat.*

About my brother, I am confident that things stand just as I have always wanted them and worked to make them. There are many signs of it, not least that his wife is pregnant. ... **Little Tullia is putting you into court — without calling a guarantor.** (Cicero, *ad Atticum* 1.10.6)

Linguistic features tested

Production-mode signal in Cicero, *ad Atticum*. AUTO = 46 letters; DICT = 19. Significance: Fisher exact (binary) or bootstrapped two-sided test (continuous). For the full methodological apparatus, see OSF via the QR code below.

A. Features absent from dictated letters *binary, presence per letter*

	AUTO	DICT	<i>p</i>
future imperatives	17/46	0/19	0.001
long perfects (1st conj., uncontracted)	4/46	0/19	0.31
<i>uncontracted forms (novisse, iudicavisse) vs. syncopated (nosse, iudicasse); cf. Hilmarsdóttir, forthcoming.</i>			
<i>ego autem</i>	7/46	0/19	0.10
adversative <i>quamquam</i>	5/46	0/19	0.31

B. Rate shifts in dictated letters *continuous, per-letter rate or ratio*

	AUTO	DICT	<i>p</i>
<i>velim</i>	2.02 ‰	3.83 ‰	0.029
<i>rate of velim per 1,000 tokens.</i>			
exclamations	0.87 ‰	2.74 ‰	0.003
<i>rate of mehercule, hercle, obsecro, and exclamatory o per 1,000 tokens.</i>			
<i>nec</i> ratio	0.30	0.53	0.026
<i>nec as a share of {nec, neque}; defined only for letters containing either form.</i>			
<i>ac</i> / <i>atque</i> share	0.16	0.06	0.020
<i>ac</i> / <i>atque</i> as a share of { <i>et</i> , <i>ac</i> , <i>atque</i> , <i>-que</i> }.			
sentence-initial <i>et</i>	0.87 ‰	1.46 ‰	0.20 (n.s.)

C. Syntactic profile *continuous, structural, residualised on letter length*

LP proportion of sentences with main predicate in the final third by token-index. Higher ~ more periodic.

AUTO 0.000 DICT -0.084 **AUC 0.763**, $p = 0.0009$

SD standard deviation of predicate position (as a proportion of sentence length) across sentences. Higher ~ more variable.

AUTO 0.000 DICT -0.035 **AUC 0.819**, $p = 0.00006$

Bibliography, data, code, full supplementary materials

via the OSF project page

